

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

Below is an extract from a newspaper article about children in Sweden:

Do children have too much power in Sweden?

Sweden was the first country in 1979 to ban the use of physical punishment to discipline children. However, some argue that its child-centred approach has gone too far and children now rule the family instead of parents. A psychiatrist who wrote the book "How Children Took Power" says parents should listen to their children but Swedish children now tend to decide everything in families: when to go to bed, what to eat, where to go on vacation, even what to watch on TV.

He adds that not disciplining Swedish children or setting boundaries from a young age has led them to have expectations that are too high, and they think that life is too hard for them. This has resulted in a sharp increase of anxiety problems, self-harming and children being unprepared for adulthood. Teachers have complained that students have become bad mannered and uncontrollable, frequently using foul language and not caring about schoolwork. Another expert feels because of Sweden's emphasis on democracy and equality, Swedish parents try to be *too* democratic. Parents should act like parents and not act like friends. They should make decisions, take control, and not try to be popular all the time.

Nonetheless, some people feel that the Swedish parenting style is successful. Swedish children are very outspoken and can express their opinions well. On the whole, Swedish youths still top international rankings of well-being.

During a class on Critical Thinking, your group is given the discussion topic "Do you agree that children will have too much power if they are not disciplined?" You may want to talk about:

- whether Hong Kong children have too much power
- the positive effects of disciplining children
- the negative effects of disciplining children
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Do your parents listen to you?
2. Do your parents allow you to decide what time to come home?
3. What type of punishment is worse for you – no TV or no phone?
4. Are Hong Kong children over-protected?
5. What decisions should children be allowed to make?
6. Do you feel you had enough freedom when you were growing up?
7. Should parents act like friends to their children?
8. Should a family be run as a democracy?